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Editor in Chief
William Z. Slany

Editors
Lisle A. Rose
Neal H. Petersen

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It seems to me self-evident that, so long as the arms race continues, the ineluctable logic of our position leaves us without choice except to acquire the greatest possible firepower in the shortest possible time. It seems to me equally self-evident that the basic decisions on H-bomb requirements must be reached now.

Attached to this letter is a chronology which I had prepared on the leading events in the formulation of our atomic production policy over the past six years.[2] The chronology is a long one, and some parts of it do not make for happy reading. In case you find it difficult to agree with the views expressed in this letter, I hope that you will not think it presumptuous of me to request that you and your highest counsellors read the attached paper. I profoundly hope that, six years hence, our military planners will be able to look back upon their recommendations in the hydrogen program and find satisfaction in the fact that some of the early delays encountered in the atomic program were not repeated.

I am sure I do not need to say that I write this letter with intense personal anguish. I share what I know are your own feelings of horror at the thought of these hideous weapons entering into the arsenals of the world. Yet overwhelming American superiority in H-bombs may well be the decisive means of keeping open the future for peace. It is one of the paradoxes of history that the President, who has worked harder and done more for world peace than any of his predecessors, has also been required—in behalf of peace—to meet the issue of hydrogen weapons.

If we carry on the fight for peace which you have launched, I remain convinced that we will yet win through to victory without war.

Very respectfully yours,

BRIEN MCMAHON

[2] Not printed.

330.13/6-252: Telegram

The Secretary of State to the United States Mission at the United Nations [1]

SECRET WASHINGTON, June 2, 1952—6:37 p.m.

465. Re Disarmament. In answering Soviet questions concerning reference to China in numerical limitation proposals and any further questions directed to same subject Dept suggests following

[1] Drafted by Bechhoefer; cleared by Perkins and Martin of CA, Bacon of FE, and Meeker of L/UNA; approved by Sanders of UNA.

general principles. (1) Preferable to confine answers to specific questions and not anticipate issues which may be raised in further questions. (2) General line on initial answer is that for purposes of these proposals China is geographic area and that accordingly proposals applicable to armed forces of China Mainland. (3) In referring to further procedural steps in securing disarmament, i.e., consultations among concerned states and world conference—important to avoid any implication that Commies will necessarily continue to be in control of China Mainland in future or that proposals portend any change in US policy of dealing with National Govt as Govt of China. If necessary to deal at all with future representation suggest use line that all authorities having substantial military power must be heard to bring them into effective system of disarmament. (4) FYI US position is that sovereignty over Formosa not yet finally determined therefore seek to avoid issue of whether Formosa part of China for purposes of determining numerical ceilings.

ACHESON

[illegible]

Memorandum by the Director of the Policy Planning Staff (Nitze) to the Secretary of State [1]

TOP SECRET [WASHINGTON,] June 9, 1952.

Problem

To determine the desirability of proceeding with the thermonuclear test now scheduled for December 1952. [2]

Discussion

The problem can be considered in terms of four of its aspects:

An international agreement not to conduct further tests as a part of a disarmament program;

An international agreement as a means of avoiding the successful development of thermonuclear weapons by either side;

The desirability of a test before the United States is prepared to produce weapons and at a time when any successful test in the thermonuclear field may have a significant effect on Soviet decisions;

The effect of the Presidential election on the decision to proceed with a test in December.

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[1] A handwritten notation on the margin indicates that the Secretary had returned the source text.

[2] Regarding U.S. nuclear and thermonuclear testing between 1952 and 1954, see the editorial note, p. 881.